

A FIELD GUIDE

The rate the partners approved is not necessarily the rate clients pay

Prepare the client conversation, set the boundary for the first no,
and check the invoices.



The handover between partner approval and the client invoice determines whether a new rate holds.

Partner approval does not tell me what clients will pay. Before announcing a new rate, I would give account leads an explanation they can use, decide what the first refusal may change, and schedule an account-by-account invoice review.

WRITTEN FOR

Managing partners at professional-services firms planning a rate change

BUILT FROM

One webinar with Maya Chen. Every quote and figure is checked against the recording and marked with the moment it was said.

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Approval does not mean the new rate held

Last year, we reviewed 40 pricing changes at services firms. Partners unanimously approved 31 of them, yet 19 of those 31 had quietly reverted within 90 days. These are observations from our review, not an industry benchmark.

19 of those 31

Unanimously approved changes that quietly reverted

From our review of 40 pricing changes at services firms last year.

● SAID AT 00:45

Approval settles a decision inside the firm. It does not settle what an account lead says when a client asks for the old rate, or what appears on the invoice. After the partner meeting, I would ask who is responsible for carrying the decision through.

A number and a date are not enough

I often see the account lead receive the new number and its start date, then become responsible for explaining both to a client. A slide records the decision. It rarely gives someone words they can use in a conversation.

I would put the writing with the partner who argued for the change. That partner should turn the firm's reasoning into an explanation of what changed for the client. Otherwise, each account lead is left to make that translation alone.

Before the announcement, ask whether account leads can explain the change aloud. Distributing the new rate is not the same as preparing them to discuss it.

“ *The spreadsheet was never the problem. The handover was.*

● SOURCE · 01:09

Write the client sentence

I ask partners to prepare one sentence explaining what changed and why it is worth it to the client, then one paragraph for the first objection. These should be working words, not a script.

PREPARE THE CLIENT EXPLANATION

01

Explain the change

Write one sentence on what changed and why it is worth it to the client.

02

Prepare the objection

Write one paragraph for the first objection the account lead expects.

03

Say it aloud

Have the account lead speak both parts. Rewrite anything that sounds like a memo.

Ask the account lead to say both aloud. If the wording sounds like an internal memo, rewrite it before the client call.

“

We ask partners to write what we call the client sentence. One sentence that explains what changed and why it is worth it to the client, not to us. Then one paragraph for the first objection.

● SOURCE · 02:34

Hear what the old-rate question is testing

A client may say they have always paid the old rate. I would not treat that as an automatic reason to concede. It can test whether the person presenting the new rate believes it will hold.

Prepare for that question explicitly. The account lead should be able to acknowledge it, explain the change and continue the conversation without revising the rate on the spot. Practise before the call, not while the client is waiting for an answer.

“ *‘We’ve always paid the old rate.’ Which isn’t really an objection, it’s a test. The client wants to know if you believe the new number. If the account lead hesitates, the client has their answer.*

● SOURCE · 02:55

Decide what the first no may change

The first refusal is the wrong moment to decide which parts of the offer are negotiable. Without an agreed boundary, the account lead must make that decision while the client is waiting.

DECIDE DURING THE CALL	SET THE BOUNDARY BEFOREHAND
The account lead judges each refusal alone.	The account lead knows what the first no may change.
Scope and payment terms have no agreed position.	Scope or payment terms may flex.
The rate may move in the first conversation.	The rate stays in place during that conversation.

I would settle the boundary before announcing the change. Scope or payment terms may flex; the rate does not move in the first conversation. Write down that distinction for everyone who will speak with clients.

“ Before you announce anything, decide what a first no may change and what it may not. Maybe the scope can flex, maybe the payment terms can flex. But the rate does not move on the first conversation.

● SOURCE · 03:17

Put the invoice review in the calendar now

An agreement records the intended rate. It does not show what the client was invoiced. I would schedule an account-by-account invoice review for ninety days after the change. For most of our clients, that is roughly one renewal cycle; it is also where we saw reversions cluster.

Ninety days

After the change,
review invoices account
by account

Check what was actually invoiced, not
what was agreed.

● SAID AT 03:44

Set the date and name the owners before the announcement. At the review, compare each account's intended new rate with what was invoiced. That is where I would look for quiet reversions.

“ *Ninety days after the change, sit down and look at what was actually invoiced, account by account. Not what was agreed. What was invoiced. That's where you find the quiet reversions.*

● SOURCE · 03:44

Use this on your next decision.

Work through the list with your team. Each step comes from the guide; the order matters.

☐ Ask the partner who argued for the change to write the client sentence and a paragraph for the first objection.

OWNER

☐ Have account leads say both aloud before client calls.

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☐ Agree before announcing what the first no may change. Scope or payment terms may flex; the rate does not move in the first conversation.

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☐ Put a ninety-day, account-by-account invoice review in the calendar with named owners.

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☐ Compare what was invoiced with the intended new rate. If you are planning a change, book a 30-minute pricing review with Northstar Advisory to examine the preparation.

OWNER

NEXT STEP

Book a 30-minute pricing review

Continue the conversation with Northstar Advisory and turn the ideas in this guide into a plan for your situation.

[northstaradvisory.example](#) →

